

Dynamic duo: The Indian badminton women's doubles pair of Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand (facing page) clicked almost instantly as the pair finished runner-up in its very first tournament together — the Polish International 2021. PICS: NAGARA GOPAL

improve those small areas, we can beat them.

Which areas need improvement to beat top pairs such as Liu-Tan?

Treesa: Play-wise, we are equal to those pairs, but physically and mentally, we need to be stronger to get the crucial points.

You started your doubles journey under coach Arun Vishnu. Now, B. Sumeeth Reddy has become your coach.

Treesa: We have learnt a lot from both the coaches. When Arun *bhaiya* was there, we had just started. We began to compete internationally, which was new for us. Bit by bit, standing on the side, he helped both of us improve our game. Sumeeth *bhaiya* has just started to coach us, and I am so grateful that he is there for us.

In January (when they were ranked World No. 9), not only did you break into the Top 10, but you also went past the all-time highest ranking for an Indian women's doubles pair, which earlier belonged to Jwala Gutta and Ashwini Ponnappa, who were World No. 10 at one point.

Gayatri: I definitely didn't know that we crossed them in the rankings — that's not something we were looking for. We were really happy to break into the top 10, and it's just a nice feeling. It was overwhelming.

Treesa: When we played the World Tour Finals in 2024, that was the last time Arun *bhaiya* was our coach. He told us that India's best women's doubles ranking has been World No. 10. If you manage to go higher, it will become history.

You were the only Indian representatives at the BWF World



Tour Finals in Hangzhou last year. Tell us about the experience of making your debut at the season-ending event.

Gayatri: We played against Liu-Tan in the first match. It was close. We won against the Malaysians (Pearly Tan and Thinaah Muralitharan). We were confident playing against the Japanese pair (Nami Matsuyama and Chiharu Shida) but it didn't go our way. Even getting to contend against those pairs has been a great learning for us.

Treesa: I had always seen the players playing on the red mat on

TV. I also wanted to play on the red mat. The stadium and the ambience were great. We played really good matches there and gained a lot of experience.

Tell us about the toughest environment you have faced during a tournament?

Treesa: Last year, we faced the Indonesians (Apriyani Rahayu and Siti Fadia Silva Ramadhanti) at the All England Open.

Obviously, wherever you go, the Indonesian fans will be there. The audience was shouting more than